

The French Revolution

The French Revolution, which began in 1789, was one of the most consequential upheavals in modern history. It swept away the absolute monarchy of France, challenged the privileges of the aristocracy and the church, and spread ideas of liberty, equality, and citizenship across Europe.

The causes of the revolution were many. France faced a severe financial crisis after years of costly wars and lavish royal spending. The tax burden fell heavily on the common people, known as the Third Estate, while the nobility and clergy were largely exempt. Enlightenment thinkers such as Rousseau and Voltaire had spread ideas that questioned the divine right of kings and argued for popular sovereignty. Poor harvests drove up the price of bread, sharpening popular anger.

In 1789 the Estates-General was convened for the first time in over a century. When the Third Estate was denied equal voting power, its members broke away and declared themselves the National Assembly, vowing not to disband until France had a constitution. Soon after, on the fourteenth of July, a Parisian crowd stormed the Bastille, a royal fortress and prison that symbolized royal tyranny. This event became the enduring symbol of the revolution.

The Assembly abolished feudal privileges and issued the Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen, which proclaimed that men are born free and equal in rights. The monarchy was at first retained as a constitutional monarchy, but tensions grew as King Louis the Sixteenth resisted reform and attempted to flee the country.

The revolution entered a radical phase known as the Reign of Terror, led by Maximilien Robespierre and the Committee of Public Safety. Thousands suspected of disloyalty were executed by guillotine, including the king and queen. The Terror ended when Robespierre himself was overthrown and executed in 1794.

The revolution eventually gave way to the rise of Napoleon Bonaparte, a general who seized power in 1799 and later crowned himself emperor. Though the revolution did not achieve lasting democracy, it permanently ended feudalism in France and inspired movements for rights and self-government worldwide.